

Final Literature Review:

Why Large Systems Fail: An Assessment of Three Complex Systems and Their Failure Modes

Group 17

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Course

IEE556: Introduction to Systems Engineering

Abstract

The intention of this paper is to review and assess critical failures in large systems, how these come to be, and what proactive measures may be taken to prevent recurrence. To this end, three large individual systems are reviewed, using a holistic approach, to understand and explain why and how different large systems fail, and to attempt to find common symptoms of such failures.

In the first case study, the failure of large businesses is assessed. This is done via an evaluation of Nokia, where the systemic mis-management of complexity, technical inertia, and the failure to adapt to a new ecosystem resulted in the company collapsing due to systemic failures. This paper reviews these failure modes by using a systems engineering approach, utilizing the five dimensions of failure to identify and understand the system's gaps.

In the second case study, the failure modes of electric power grids are presented. The consequences of severe weather events and climate conditions are discussed. This is done via an evaluation of historical and projected failures related to the U.S. Southwest and Texas power grids. The paper also presents proposed solutions and preventive measures to failures in power grids due to weather-related events. In addition, the impact of cascading failures in such systems is explained. The use of relevant metrics is discussed in an effort to understand how such propagating failures may be quantified. Furthermore, the use of system modeling is introduced, with the intention of understanding and proactively identifying those component failures with higher probabilities of propagation.

In the third case study, the failure modes of space missions, as well as the resulting impact and consequences, are assessed. To this end, space mission failures such as with the Mars Climate Orbiter are presented. This paper discusses the importance of communication, interface control, verification processes, and attentiveness from government agencies to problems. An evaluation of how these complex systems could fail if these system properties are not properly managed is also completed. In addition, the methods agencies such as NASA use to learn from these events are reviewed.

Finally, the paper concludes with a summarized assessment relating the three case studies. The paper discusses cascading effects, failures to adapt to a greater system, the implementation of solutions or preventive measures based on lessons learned or adequate modeling, the quantification of risk via metrics, the proper management of organizations, and how these attributes become critical to the success and proper function of large systems.

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Case Study 1: Failures in Large Businesses

Background

All organizations function as large systems, which are inherently prone to systemic failure. While some organizations manage to navigate these vulnerabilities, others cave to them. Consequently, Nokia serves as a compelling case study to examine how and why large business systems fail. Nokia's transition from a dominant global market leader to a "total fiasco" serves as a seminal case study in the failure of large-scale systems. While often simplified as a failure of "innovation," a deeper literature review reveals a systemic collapse involving technical inertia, organizational complexity, and a failure to move up the Capability Maturity Model (CMM). By analyzing Nokia through the five dimensions of failure: size, quality, cost, schedule, and complexity, it becomes clear that the organization succumbed to the exact pitfalls identified in systems engineering theory (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Theoretical Dimensions of Failure in the Nokia System

The systems engineering literature defines failure through five primary dimensions: size, quality, cost, schedule, and complexity. Nokia's downfall was not triggered by a single event but by a misalignment across all five.

Complexity and Size:

At its peak, Nokia was a massive system with over 130,000 employees. This immense size created a "Growth Paradox," where the buildup of bureaucracy (including over 300 Vice Presidents) caused the system to lose its internal metabolism and speed. The complexity reached a point where management could no longer separate individual functions, causing considerable delays in decision-making processes (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Quality:

In systems engineering, quality is defined by what is acceptable to the customer. Nokia failed to forecast that customer needs had shifted from hardware reliability to the User Experience (UX) and Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) standards set by the Apple iPhone (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Schedule and Cost:

Despite spending approximately \$3.9 billion on R&D in 2010 (nearly three times the average of its rivals), Nokia failed to deliver competitive products on a viable schedule. Their flagship models were often delivered to market too late to compete with rapidly evolving rivals like Apple and Samsung (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Managerial Pitfalls: Inertia and the Legacy Trap

A primary reason for system failure is Inertia, which occurs when an organization tries to match new technology to existing manual business processes instead of re-engineering the process. Nokia exhibited this inertia by attempting to adapt its legacy Symbian OS to a modern, touch-screen market. Symbian was a "Legacy" system originally written for low-power CPUs (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Systems theory suggests that initial low investment in new architecture leads to long-term bad decisions that cannot be redone. By clinging to Symbian, Nokia suffered from software

fragmentation, where product-specific software was often only compatible with one certain device (Alibage & Weber, 2018). This aligns with the "guaranteed ways to fail," specifically changing a system to support critical new requirements during final development stages.

Organizational Immaturity: The CMM Model

The Capability Maturity Model (CMM) measures how well-developed an organization's management processes are. Nokia's history shows a regression through levels discussed below.

The Optimizing Era (Level 5):

During the mid-1990s, Nokia operated as a high-maturity organization focused on value-based leadership and continuous improvement (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

The Chaotic Regression (Level 1):

By 2011, Nokia's processes became ad-hoc and chaotic, which is characteristic of CMM Level 1. The "Burning Platform" memo was a clear admission that the existing system worked "disastrously in crisis situations" (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Failure of Methodology:

Nokia ignored the finding that linear "Big Bang" delivery of a solution seldom works. Instead of an incremental roll-out, the company made a sudden, desperate pivot to the Microsoft Windows Phone platform, which failed to stabilize the organization (Alibage & Weber, 2018; Huy & Vuori, 2015).

Governance and the "Requirements Explosion"

Senior Management governance is critical for making timely decisions at the right level. However, Nokia's internal metabolism was slowed by a "Requirements Explosion". Between 1995 and 2013, the company released 406 different models, including 47 models in 2008 alone. This overabundance of products showed a lack of focus, making it impossible to produce a single "iPhone killer" (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Analysis of Data: Financial Performance

The breakdown of Nokia's management system is visible in its financial data. As shown in the literature, the operating profit for Nokia's mobile business plummeted from 21.7% in 2007 to 3.7% by 2011 (Alibage & Weber, 2018). While the company was technically "doing things right" by filing a record number of patents, it was not "doing the right things" to satisfy the changing market (Alibage & Weber, 2018).

Summary

The failure of Nokia was a failure of Systems Engineering governance. By succumbing to Inertia, failing to manage Complexity, and regressing into a chaotic state of organizational maturity, the company became unpredictable and unable to compete. Their decline proves that even a vast portfolio of patents cannot save a system that fails to adapt its core platform to a new ecosystem.

Case Study 2: Failures in Electric Power Grids

Background

Although humanity's reliance on electricity is relatively new from a historical perspective with its adoption within the last century, the development of such systems as electric power grids has been extended as a cultural way of life in many countries, rather than a non-essential service; many nations and communities rely on electric power to light their homes, to ease production of critical products and exports, and to provide power for essential facets of modern living, such as educational institutions, hospitals, and the refrigeration of food and beverages. Furthermore, the infrastructure of electric power grids has been linked to long term economic regional growth in some areas, as has been observed in China (Xu et al., 2021).

At its core, a power grid may be separated into three main sections: generation, transmission and distribution (Koç et al., 2014). The generation portion is the section which actually generates the electricity (e.g., a power plant), the transmission portion is the network via which electricity is sent to its customers (e.g., power lines), and finally, the distribution is how the electricity is delivered to its customers (e.g., residential areas), and at what voltage (Koç et al., 2014).

Due to their large complexity and society's reliance on them, the study of how these systems can fail, as well as how to prevent their failure, is of much interest, as its impact on modern society is very consequential. These consequences vary, and some have even been quantified financially as losses, with large individual events in the North American power grid having been documented to have had an economic impact in the tens of billions of dollars (Yang et al., 2017). The focus of this case study is to understand how failures in electric power grids occur, the methods and models that may be useful to predict such failures, and the ways in which improvements upon these systems can be made.

Cascading Failures

One mechanism by which power grids may fail and result in blackouts is via cascading failures. In essence, cascading failures are initiated by the failure of an individual system component, which then propagates to the entire system, causing the overall system to fail; to expand upon this in a simpler way, cascading failures related to power grids happen in much the same way in which a single misaligned gear can induce failure upon a complex system of gears (Koç et al., 2014).

As such, it is imperative that in designing electrical grids, that their robustness is further developed. In this context, the robustness of a system refers to the systems' ability to prevent failures as a result of a partial failure from its individual components, and robustness in this sense may be quantified via the calculation of the effective graph resistance of the power grid, which is the sum of the individual potential differences between two links when a current moves from one link to the other (Koç et al., 2014). Therefore, the interconnections of electric lines and buses, i.e., topology, and the reactance and loading capacity of the transmission lines in the electric grid becomes important, as these data are required to compute the aforementioned effective graph resistance to assess vulnerabilities (Koç et al., 2014).

A key problem with identifying individual component failures is that for such complex systems as electric power grids, identifying a good model to accurately predict failures becomes a gargantuan task (Yang et al., 2017). In many cases, when several components fail, it is difficult to identify which of those components was key in propagating the failures to the greater system,

and distinguishing them from components whose failures would not have propagated in similar fashion (Yang et al., 2017). This modeling problem is expounded by the effects of the given season or by that of the power demand in a given region, operating conditions which may vary wildly and, as a result, a multivariate analysis of cascade vulnerabilities is critical to understand failures in these types of systems (Yang et al., 2017).

Interestingly, certain findings have deemed the transmission portion of the power grid system less consequential to propagating vulnerabilities than other components, with less than one percent of transmission lines being found to be vulnerable under any given condition (Yang et al., 2017). In certain studies, the links where the transmission lines connect showed few overall major cascading failures and rather found smaller, secondary failures to be more common (Yang et al., 2017). As a result, one method to improve upon the design of electric grids to reduce the cascading nature of the failure is thus to have more backup paths where the electricity may flow in case of individual component failure of one of the electrical paths (Koç et al., 2014).

Weather-Related Failures

A frustrating side effect of real world living is that many complex systems with which society interacts in day to day life may be adversely affected by variables outside what is considered the boundaries of the system in question. This is typical, since humans live in a complex system of systems, unforeseen conditions like weather events and drastic temperature changes often become a centerpiece of critical failures in large and complex systems, such as electric power grids. Certain regions, such as the U.S. desert southwest, are expected to have temperature increases up to 5°C by mid-century, which will stretch the capabilities and function of the electric power grid due to increased current loads and reduced component lifespans (Burillo et al., 2016).

According to certain studies, regardless of the robustness and state of the electric power grid itself, the expected changes in temperature in regions like Arizona have been modeled and are expected to significantly increase the rate of failure of components, from mechanical to power-based failures, which in turn propagate via cascade as previously discussed (Burillo et al., 2016). Per certain findings, an increase of up to 1°C may increase the probability of mechanical failures in transmission lines by close to 200%, meaning that transmission lines expected to last longer will fail much sooner than expected or planned, as is the case with overhead ACSR lines which are generally modeled to last 70 years, but under these conditions could instead fail in about 25 years (Burillo et al., 2016).

The consequences of temperature increases go on, with failures in the electric grid more than doubling for increases of 1°C, due to insufficient electricity generation (Burillo et al., 2016). Under such conditions, the occurrence of power failures due to the individual failure of components like substations and transformers is also projected to increase by 22x and 30x, respectively (Burillo et al., 2016). Per these findings, if a proactive approach and preventive measures aren't set up and implemented to mitigate the damages to electric grid infrastructure as a result of changing temperatures, then the likelihood of a cascading failure may rise to once every 2 or 3 years, compared to the likelihood of a cascading failure as of 2016 which was modeled at 20 to 30 years (Burillo et al., 2016).

In the U.S., weather-related electric power grid failures are not isolated to temperature increases in desert regions. The western power grid is in fact one of the sturdier electric grids and it happens to be weakened by rising temperatures in the region (Burillo et al., 2016). The Texas electric grid is an example of a power grid whose operation has historically been shown to be

severely disrupted by widespread power outages, due to extreme storms such as tropical cyclones and hurricanes in the region (Stürmer et al., 2024). Certain studies have demonstrated that in such cases, hardening as little as one percent of the transmission lines in the Texas electric power grid can make it less probable for highly disruptive blackouts to occur, with findings of between five to twenty times less likely (Stürmer et al., 2024).

Summary

In this case study we have described the impact of failures in electric power grids resulting from several root causes. The effects of cascading, where individual components serve as initial propagators resulting in an overall system failure, were reviewed.

Proper evaluation of the power grid, via utilization of metrics such as the effective graph resistance, with a proper understanding of the interconnections between transmission lines and the power grid topology, may serve to better model electric power grids and function to detect potential vulnerabilities (Koç et al., 2014; Yang et al., 2017). The addition of more transmission lines may be implemented to act as backup paths in cases when the main lines fail, thereby preventing a single point of failure from a given link or component (Koç et al., 2014).

The effects of weather were also reviewed and were found to have a significant effect as an extraneous force in a greater system causing power grid failures. Preventive measures and proper planning can effectively serve to mitigate these weather effects, as well as proper inspections and regular equipment maintenance (Burillo et al., 2016). For severe storms, the effects on the power grid may be reduced in severity via the hardening of critical lines as could be the case with the Texas power grid (Stürmer et al., 2024).

In summary, although failures in electric power grids may be catastrophic and costly, there are methods that governments and communities can employ to mitigate the damage and to proactively prepare for projected failures in the future.

Case Study 3: Failures in Space Missions

Background

Large aerospace systems represent some of the most complex engineering endeavors undertaken by humanity. These systems integrate hardware, software, communication networks, human operators, and organizational processes across multiple teams and locations. Due to this complexity, failures often emerge not from a single technical defect, but from the interaction of multiple system components and management decisions. The loss of the Mars Climate Orbiter (MCO) in 1999 remains one of the most widely studied examples of systems engineering failure.

The Mars Climate Orbiter was launched on December 11, 1998, as part of NASA's Mars Surveyor Program. The mission's objective was to study the Martian atmosphere, climate patterns, and water distribution. After a nine-month journey to Mars, the spacecraft was lost during orbital insertion when it entered the Martian atmosphere at a significantly lower altitude than intended. Subsequent investigations revealed that the failure was caused by a mismatch between imperial and metric units used by different project teams (Stephenson et al., 1999). While often remembered as a simple unit conversion error, literature suggests the failure was actually the result of deeper issues involving interface management, communication, verification processes, and organizational oversight.

Figure 1 summarizes the major mission events from launch to investigation. This timeline is useful because it shows that the failure did not occur immediately at launch. Instead, the error accumulated during cruise operations and became mission-ending during the final orbit insertion phase (Stephenson et al., 1999).

Interface Management Failure

One of the primary causes of failure was poor interface management between organizations responsible for mission operations. NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory utilized metric units for navigation calculations, while Lockheed Martin generated thrust data using imperial units. The discrepancy resulted in navigation data being incorrectly interpreted throughout the mission lifecycle (Stephenson et al., 1999).

From a systems engineering perspective, interface management is critical because modern systems frequently require multiple organizations to interact through shared technical data. The Mars Climate Orbiter demonstrates how a poorly controlled interface can propagate small errors throughout an entire system. Although the spacecraft itself functioned as designed, the interaction between organizational subsystems failed.

As shown in Figure 2, the navigation error caused the spacecraft to approach Mars at a significantly lower altitude than intended (National Aeronautics and Space Administration/Jet Propulsion Laboratory, 1999). The spacecraft was designed to enter orbit approximately 140 to 150 km above the Martian surface. However, the accumulated navigation error resulted in an estimated altitude of approximately 57 km, causing atmospheric destruction or loss of communication. The figure demonstrates how a seemingly minor interface discrepancy propagated throughout the mission and ultimately resulted in total system failure.

Table 1 further separates the intended and actual measurement units used across the system interface (Stephenson et al., 1999). The table shows that the failure was not caused by the absence of technical data. Instead, the failure was caused by inconsistent interpretation of shared technical data across organizational boundaries.

Verification and Validation Deficiencies

Systems engineering emphasizes verification and validation to ensure that systems are built correctly and that they satisfy mission requirements. The investigation board concluded that the navigation discrepancies should have been detected through routine verification procedures. However, inadequate review processes allowed the error to persist throughout the mission (Stephenson et al., 1999).

Several trajectory deviations occurred during the mission's cruise phase. Rather than identifying these anomalies as indicators of a systemic problem, project teams attributed them to acceptable operational variation. As a result, opportunities to detect and correct the issue were missed.

Figure 3 illustrates how a relatively minor technical issue evolved into a mission-ending event (Stephenson et al., 1999). The issue was not solely the unit conversion error itself, but the absence of a robust process capable of detecting and correcting the error before mission completion.

Organizational Communication Failures

Research in systems engineering consistently identifies communication as a critical contributor to project success. The Mars Climate Orbiter investigation found that communication between NASA teams and contractors was fragmented and insufficiently coordinated (Stephenson et al., 1999).

Large systems require continuous information exchange among engineers, managers, software developers, and operational personnel. In the MCO program, responsibility for navigation calculations and mission oversight was distributed across multiple organizations. Without effective communication mechanisms, important assumptions regarding measurement units remained unchallenged.

This issue aligns closely with systems engineering literature, which identifies communication breakdowns as a recurring source of large-scale system failures. Similar communication failures have been observed in aerospace accidents, power grid outages, and software project collapses.

Complexity and Organizational Oversight

The failure of the Mars Climate Orbiter also illustrates the challenges associated with managing complex systems. Complexity increases as additional stakeholders, interfaces, requirements, and technical dependencies are introduced. While the MCO mission was smaller than many flagship NASA programs, it still involved numerous teams operating within a highly integrated technical environment.

NASA's investigation concluded that project management underestimated the risks associated with system integration and oversight. Cost-saving measures implemented under the Faster, Better, Cheaper philosophy reduced available resources for independent reviews and systems engineering activities (Stephenson et al., 1999). Table 2 summarizes the major systems engineering factors that contributed to the failure (Stephenson et al., 1999).

As shown in Table 2, each contributing factor extends beyond a single technical error and reflects deficiencies in systems engineering processes responsible for coordinating complex organizational and technical interactions. Figure 4 summarizes the management tradeoff often associated with the Mars Surveyor Program (Stephenson et al., 1999). The Faster, Better, Cheaper philosophy was intended to deliver lower-cost missions on shorter schedules. However, in this case, the reduced margin for review and oversight increased the risk that an integration issue could remain hidden until the final mission phase.

Comparison to Other Space System Failures

The Mars Climate Orbiter is useful as an individual case, but it also fits a broader pattern of large aerospace systems failing because of weak governance, incomplete verification, and poor communication. Table 3 compares the Mars Climate Orbiter with other major space system failures (Stephenson et al., 1999). Each case has a different technical trigger, but each also reflects a deeper systems engineering weakness.

Table 3 demonstrates that although the technical causes differed across each mission, the underlying systems engineering deficiencies remained remarkably consistent. Interface management, organizational decision making, verification, and risk management repeatedly

emerged as dominant contributors to system failure. This comparison is important because it prevents the Mars Climate Orbiter from being viewed as a simple calculation mistake. In a systems engineering context, the stronger lesson is that large systems fail when technical processes, organizational structures, and risk controls do not remain aligned.

Summary

The Mars Climate Orbiter remains a valuable case study because the underlying causes extend beyond a simple technical mistake. The mission demonstrates how large systems can fail when communication, interface control, verification processes, and organizational oversight are not adequately managed.

Several lessons emerge from the literature. Standardized interfaces must be established and rigorously controlled. Verification and validation activities should remain independent whenever possible. Communication channels between organizations must be clearly defined. Risk indicators should be investigated rather than dismissed as normal variation. Finally, systems engineering activities should not be reduced solely to achieve cost savings.

These lessons continue to influence aerospace project management and systems engineering practices throughout NASA and other organizations. More broadly, the case supports the central argument that large systems fail when management processes are unable to control complexity across the full system lifecycle.

Conclusion

This literature review examined three completely different types of large systems: a global business (Nokia), a public infrastructure network (electric power grids), and a sophisticated aerospace mission (the Mars Climate Orbiter). While these systems operate in entirely different environments, their downfalls reveal that large systems fail due to remarkably similar systems engineering weaknesses. By looking at these case studies together, we can see common patterns in how complexity, poor communication, and weak governance lead to catastrophic failure.

Ultimately, the failure of large systems is rarely caused by a single technical glitch or a random mistake. Instead, systems fail when management processes, organizational structures, and risk controls become unaligned. Trying to save money or speed up schedules by reducing oversight (such as NASA's historical "Faster, Better, Cheaper" philosophy or Nokia's rushed platform transitions) frequently results in total system collapse. To ensure the success of future large-scale systems, engineers and managers must respect complexity, enforce rigorous verification protocols, and maintain open lines of communication across all organizational boundaries.

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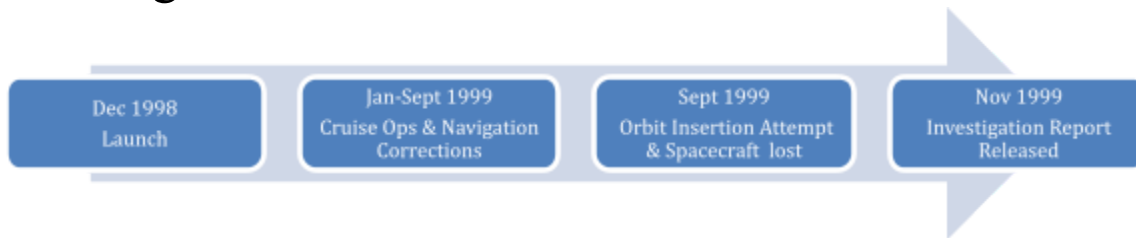


Figure 1. Timeline of major events associated with the Mars Climate Orbiter mission. Adapted from Stephenson (1999).

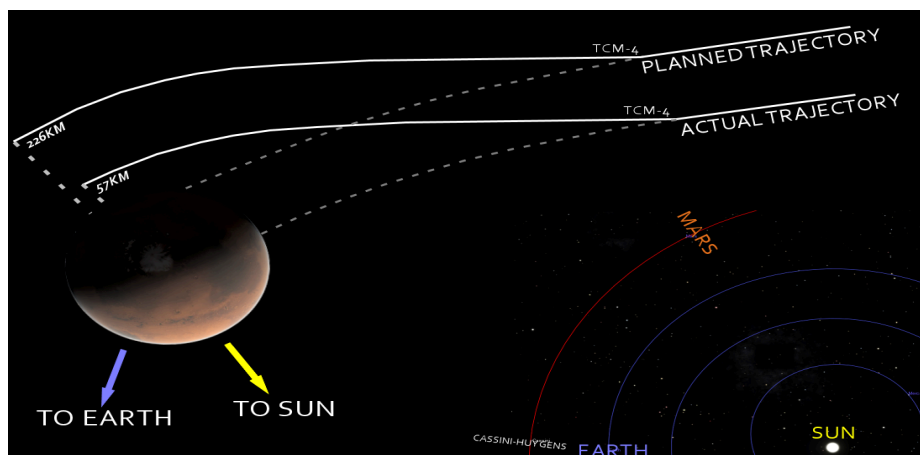


Figure 2. Mars Climate Orbiter mishap diagram illustrating the trajectory deviation caused by the metric-imperial unit mismatch. Adapted from NASA/JPL (1999).

Table 1. Interface management discrepancies contributing to mission failure. Adapted from Stephenson (1999).

System Element	Expected Unit	Actual Unit Used
Navigation team inputs	Newton-seconds	Newton-seconds
Contractor output	Newton-seconds	Pound-force seconds
Orbit calculations	Metric	Mixed units
Final navigation solution	Correct trajectory model	Incorrect trajectory model



Figure 3. Failure propagation chain leading to the loss of the Mars Climate Orbiter. Adapted from Stephenson (1999).

Table 2. Assessment of systems engineering factors contributing to mission failure. Adapted from Stephenson (1999).

Failure Area	Severity	Impact on Mission
Interface Management	High	Unit mismatch between organizations introduced navigation error
Verification & Validation	High	Error remained undetected during cruise operations
Communication	High	Assumptions regarding units were not reconciled
Risk Management	Medium	Trajectory anomalies were not escalated as systemic warning signs
Organizational Oversight	High	Independent review processes were insufficient

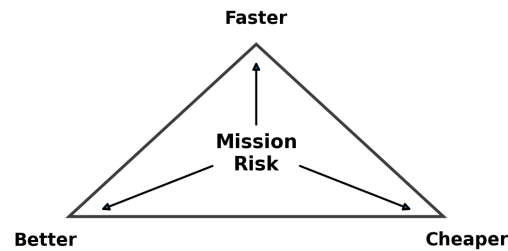


Figure 4. Conceptual representation of NASA's Faster, Better, Cheaper philosophy and the increased risks associated with reduced oversight and resources. Adapted from Stephenson (1999).

Table 3. Comparison of major aerospace system failures and their dominant contributing factors. Developed by the authors based on Stephenson et al. (1999) and the literature reviewed in this paper.

Mission	Primary Failure	Systems Engineering Lesson
Mars Climate Orbiter	Interface management	Control shared technical data across organizational boundaries
Ariane 5 Flight 501	Software reuse failure	Verify reused software against new operating conditions
Space Shuttle Challenger	Organizational decision making	Escalate safety concerns and protect engineering judgment
Space Shuttle Columbia	Risk normalization	Treat repeated anomalies as warning signs, not accepted behavior
Mars Polar Lander	Requirements verification	Validate mission-critical assumptions before operation